and the nationalist movement began, there was a small number of elite, educated, outspoken women who were entering professions and government positions so far dominated by men.

Not everyone saw this as a good thing. Some of the early male nationalists believed that a woman's place was in the home, and thought letting women study or make their own choices were 'Western' ideas that had no place in India. But when Gandhi called for both men and women to participate in the fight for freedom, women across castes, classes and religious groups joined in the thousands. At the same time, women's organizations began to push for even more reforms and guarantees from both the British and the Congress. Ideas about the roles women could play changed drastically, and women themselves demanded equal rights. The women in this section and many more like them helped lay the foundations of a more gender-equal society, which India continues to strive for even today.